AI Item Review Case Study: From Draft to Defensible Item

Prompting, auditing, and revising an AI-generated ELA item for large-scale assessment

Dr. Mary K Boudreaux, EdD
Passage: The Praline Pot, grade 5

Task. Generate one multiple-choice item for my original grade 5 story *The Praline Pot* targeting character analysis. **Principle.** AI speeds up drafting; a content expert owns every key, rationale, alignment claim, and fairness decision.

1 THE PROMPT I WROTE

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Role: You are an item writer for a state ELA test.
Passage: [full text of "The Praline Pot," with
paragraph numbers]
Task: Write ONE 4-option multiple-choice item for
grade 5 aligned to CCSS RL.5.3 (describe a
character using specific details).
Rules:
- Ask about Lise at the BEGINNING of the story.
- The key must be provable from the passage alone.
- Each distractor must reflect a specific
  misreading; write a rationale for every option.
- No negative stems; no "all of the above."
- Use neutral, respectful language about every
  character and culture.
Output: standard, stem, options A-D, key,
rationales.
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2 THE AI'S FIRST DRAFT

AI DRAFT · TAGGED RL.5.4 [1] · KEY GIVEN: B [2]

Lise is a typical impatient kid who doesn't listen to her old-fashioned Mon-mon. [3] Which detail shows this?

A. She turns the flame up high so the pralines will be done before supper.

B. She asks Mon-mon, "How do you know when it is ready?"

C. She refuses to make the pralines for the fair. [4]

D. All of the above [4]

AI rationale for B: "Asking a question shows she does not know what she is doing."

3 MY ANNOTATED REVIEW

1. **Standard does not match.** RL.5.4 is word and phrase meaning. The item asks students to describe a character, which is RL.5.3, the standard the prompt requested. A mis-tagged item corrupts the blueprint and the score report.
2. **Wrong key.** Option B is the moment Lise *starts* listening (paragraph 11), the opposite of the trait in the stem. The text supports A: she turns the flame up high because she wants to finish before supper (paragraph 6) and ignores "Not yet" (paragraphs 7 and 8). The AI's rationale confuses asking for help with not knowing.
3. **Bias and a leading stem.** "Typical impatient kid" stereotypes children, and "old-fashioned" frames the elder and her cultural knowledge as outdated, when in the story Mon-mon's knowledge is the solution. The stem also hands students the interpretation instead of asking them to make it, and it gives no paragraph reference.
4. **Weak distractors and a broken rule.** C is contradicted by paragraph 2 (Lise volunteers), so no reader would choose it. D violates the prompt, and because A is true, "All of the above" creates a second arguable answer. Neither distractor tells us anything about a student's misunderstanding.
- ✓ **What I kept.** The AI surfaced two useful text details (A and B). Both stay, and B becomes a purposeful distractor: it is true, it is about Lise, but it describes her later in the story.

4 THE REVISED ITEM

FINAL · CCSS RL.5.3 · DOK 2 · EST. DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM · KEY: B

Which detail from paragraphs 6 to 8 best shows that Lise is impatient at the beginning of the story?

Option	Rationale
A. She measures the sugar and cream into the pot.	Accurate detail from paragraph 6, but it describes an action, not a trait.
B. She turns the flame up high because she wants the pralines finished before supper.	Key. Shows she is rushing; reinforced when she ignores "Not yet" in paragraphs 7 and 8.
C. She ties on the striped apron that comes down to her knees.	From paragraph 4; suggests eagerness, not impatience, and is outside the paragraphs named.
D. She asks Mon-mon how to tell when the candy is ready.	The AI's original key. A true detail about Lise, but it shows her change later in the story (paragraph 11).

WHERE AI HELPED

- Produced a first draft and text details in seconds
- Offered options I could repurpose as distractors
- Useful as a second reader: I ask it to argue for each distractor to find weak keys

WHERE EXPERT JUDGMENT WAS REQUIRED

- Verifying the key and every rationale against the text
- Catching the mis-tagged standard
- Bias, tone, and cultural accuracy
- Enforcing item-writing rules the model ignored
- Logging AI use for the item's review record

© 2026 Dr. Mary K Boudreaux, EdD. The AI draft is illustrative: it reflects the first-pass errors I most often correct in AI-generated items. Rules applied: ELA Item Writing Guide.

See also: Grade 10 informational set